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One reporter wrote a story describing my first year in Sacramento headlined “The Political Education of Ronald Reagan.” I suppose this description of my introduction to political life wasn’t far off the mark, although the reporter might have added this was a period of “education” for Nancy, too.

For much of that first year or so, nothing went according to my plan: We kept uncovering problems nobody had told me about before; there was continuing violence on our campuses; Democratic legislators rejected my proposals right and left; moderates and conservatives in my own party couldn’t get along; and I made lots of mistakes because of inexperience.

As I remarked during one speech, “Out in California we have a form of on-the-job training: When I got to Sacramento, I felt like an Egyptian tank driver reading a set of Russian instructions. . . .”

Yes, I was learning that it was one thing to preach a sermon about reducing the size of government, another to put it into action when you’re fighting a hostile legislature determined to expand it.

In Hollywood, Nancy and I had become used to having critics take shots at us and reading things about ourselves in the papers that weren’t true. But what we found in Sacramento made our Hollywood experience seem mild by comparison.

After a while, when I’d get home from the capitol, I’d know exactly where Nancy was—in the bathtub.

I’d smell bath salts at the front door and hear her voice echoing down the hallway from the bathroom.